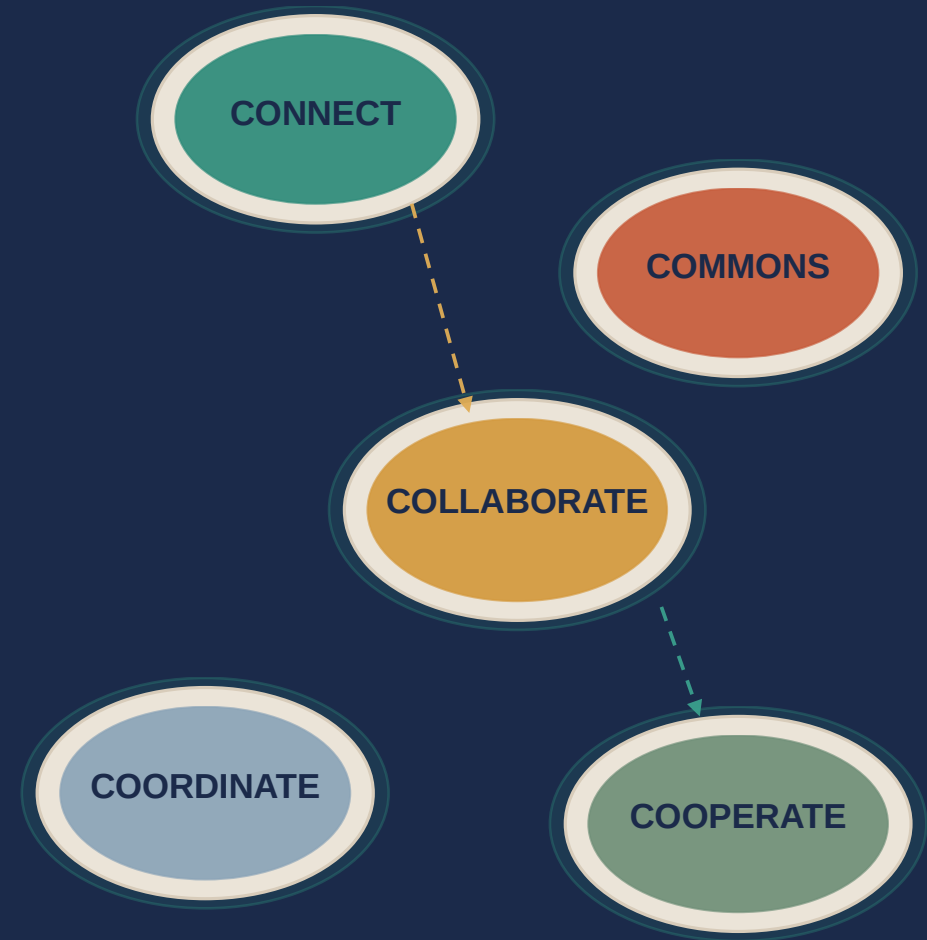


Designing how we work together

Not everything needs collaboration.

Five modes for designing relationships, openness, control, reciprocity, governance and exit.

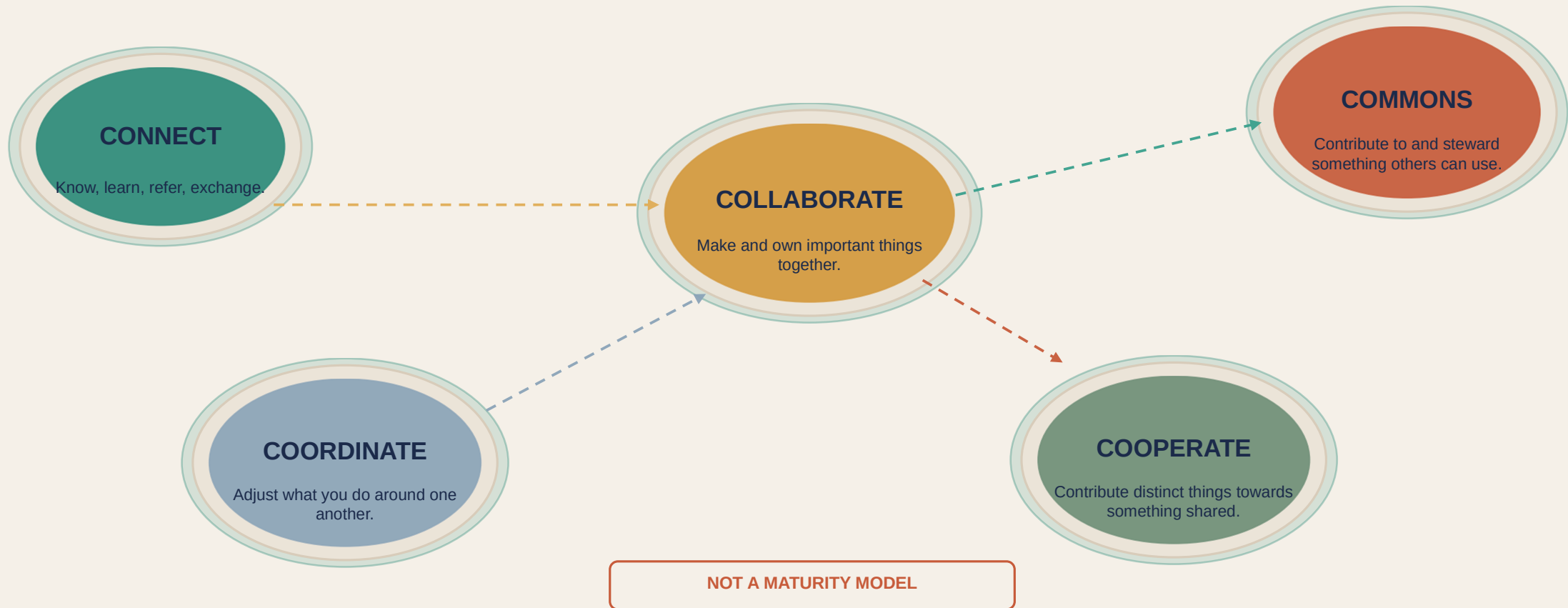
More isn't better. Choose what the work actually needs.



modes, not stages

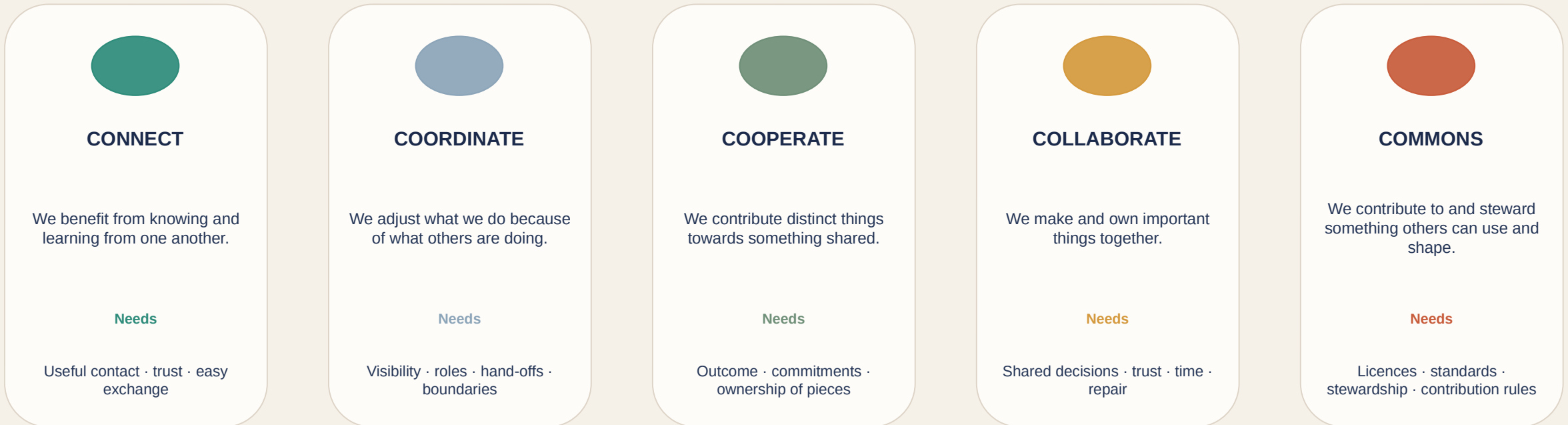
Five modes. Not stages.

You can use several at once, and move between them.



Choose the lightest mode the work needs

The modes differ in interdependence, what must be shared, and what infrastructure is worth paying for.

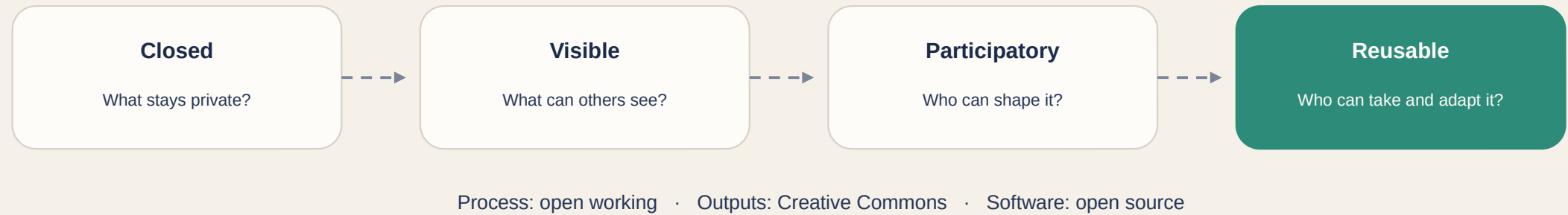


Sometimes a referral is exactly what is needed. Turning it into a “collaboration” would just add meetings.

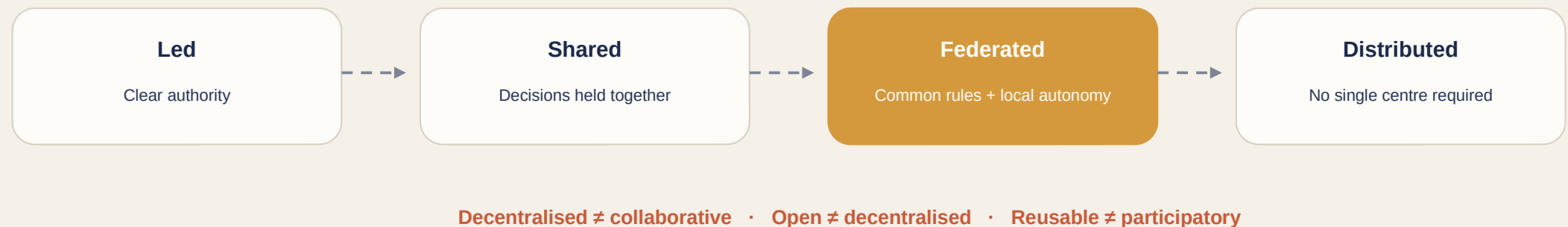
Design the environment around the mode

Open is not the same as collaborative. Distributed is not the same as open.

HOW OPEN?

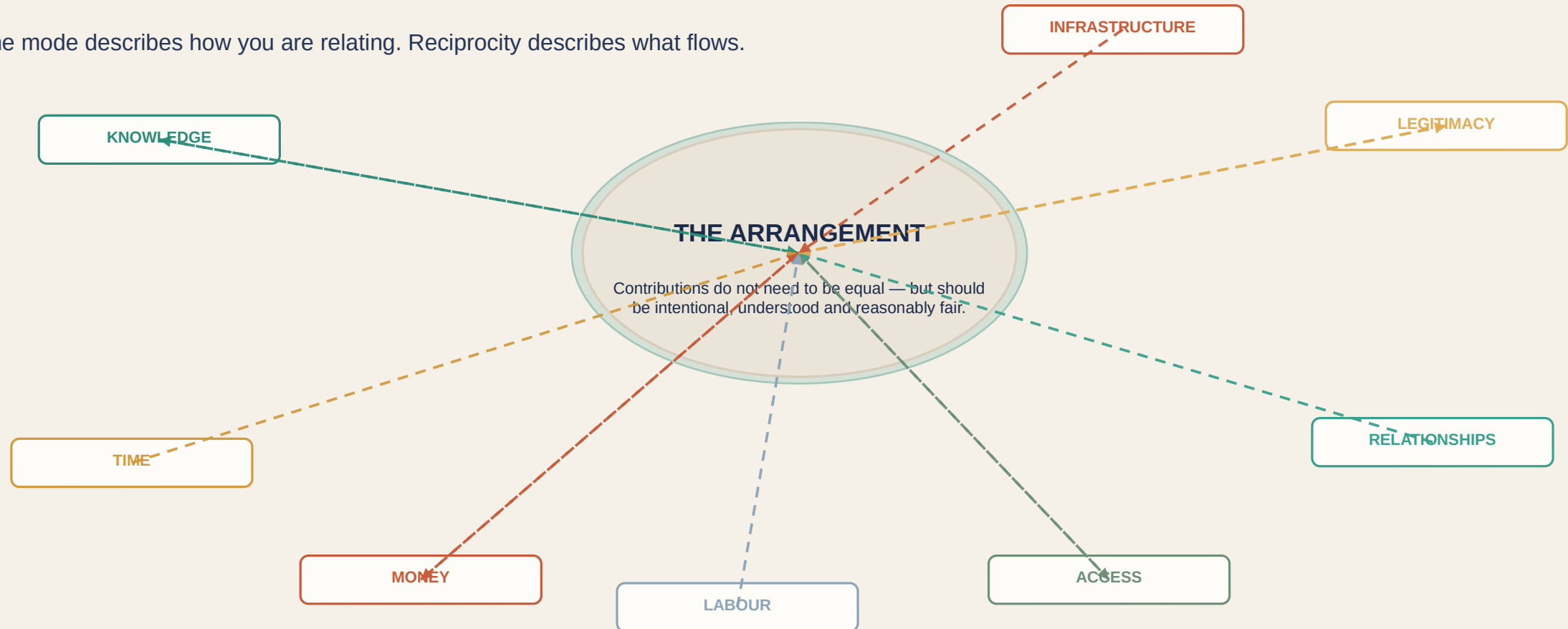


WHERE DOES CONTROL SIT?



What flows between us?

The mode describes how you are relating. Reciprocity describes what flows.



One-way exchange presented as “collaboration” deserves scrutiny.

Different modes need different infrastructure

The question is not “how collaborative are we?” but “what do we need to make this mode work well?”

MODE	WHAT IT NEEDS	GOVERNANCE QUESTION	WATCH OUT FOR
CONNECT	Light social infrastructure	Who stays connected? How?	Weak ties disappear when key people leave.
COORDINATE	Information + role infrastructure	Who does what? What needs visibility?	Hidden work, duplication and broken hand-offs.
COOPERATE	Commitment + delivery infrastructure	Who owns which piece? What is promised?	Shared goal, unequal load or vague accountability.
COLLABORATE	Relational + decision infrastructure	Who can decide? How do we disagree and repair?	One party controls the important choices.
COMMONS	Stewardship + contribution infrastructure	Who can use, change, contribute, maintain or fork?	Open to use, closed to meaningful influence.

Name the arrangement honestly. A commission, grant, procurement or consultation can be perfectly legitimate without pretending to be collaboration.

Collaboration and commons are different

You collaborate with people. You contribute to, draw from and steward a commons.

COLLABORATE

Centre of gravity	The relationship
Basic action	Make + decide together
Dependency	On one another
Infrastructure	Relationships · meetings · decisions · conflict / repair
Power question	Whose voice counts?
Exit	Change, loosen or leave the relationship

COMMONS

Centre of gravity	The shared thing
Basic action	Contribute · use · steward
Dependency	On the shared resource / infrastructure
Infrastructure	Licences · standards · repositories · documentation · contribution rules
Power question	Who controls the commons?
Exit	Leave · hand over · archive · fork

DIFFERENT INFRASTRUCTURE

Every island needs a way off

Design how the relationship can change — before changing it becomes contentious.

FINISH

PAUSE

LEAVE

LOOSEN

DEEPEN

HAND OVER

FORK

CLOSE

How will we know when?

Purpose achieved · conditions changed · costs outweigh value · participation is no longer meaningful · another mode now fits better.

Why?

Complete · changed · unsustainable · misaligned · unhealthy · evolving

How do we actually do it?

Decision · notice · commitments · data / IP / access · stewardship · communication

For a commons: can it be forked?

Before you set sail

Use these six questions to design the arrangement — then choose the mode, openness and distribution of control that fit.

1

PURPOSE

What are we actually trying to achieve together?
What would be different if this worked?

2

POWER

Who has money, authority, information and the
ability to walk away?
What power differences need naming or balancing?

3

DECISIONS

What gets decided together — and what does not?
Who can commit the organisations involved?

4

CONTRIBUTION & RECIPROCITY

What does each participant put in, and what can
they draw from?
What would feel unfair or extractive?

5

OPENNESS & OWNERSHIP

Who can see, use, change and share the work or
outputs?
What should remain private — and why?

6

CHANGE & EXIT

How will we know when this arrangement should
change?
Who decides, and what happens to the work,
money, data and relationships?

Then choose: **MODE · OPENNESS · WHERE CONTROL SITS · WHAT FLOWS · HOW IT CHANGES**